

Interim Report – Qualitative Findings on Building Effective Team Dynamics through Conflict Management and Negotiation Skill



Team- 12

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The report has been created from the interviews/discussions conducted by all the members of Team 12 with relevant working professionals. It aims to analyse key aspects of conflict management, negotiation, and team dynamics through real-world perspectives and practical experiences.

By Samarth S (23f2004763)

As scope of this project, I conducted an interview/discussion with an experienced professional currently working as the **Director of Operations at Publicis Groupe**, who got **20 years of extensive experience** in managing cross-functional teams and handling workplace conflicts in a corporate environment.

The discussion majorly focused on understanding the causes of conflict, strategies to resolve conflicts, negotiation techniques, and their impact on team performance and overall morale.

One of the key insights from the discussion was that **conflicts in teams often arise due to miscommunication, unclear roles, and differing priorities across departments**. In large organizations, where multiple teams collaborate, these differences can easily lead to misunderstandings, especially under deadlines and high-pressure situations.

The participant also emphasized that **conflict is not always negative**. If handled effectively, it can lead to better decision-making by showcasing diverse perspectives. However, conflicts become harmful when they turn personal rather than remaining within the context of task or problem.

An insightful example shared during the discussion involved a conflict between a **delivery team and a quality assurance team**, where one prioritized over speed and the other one focused on maintaining quality standards. This disagreement made delays and tension within the team. The situation was resolved by organizing a structured form of discussion, aligning both teams toward a common goal, and creating a balanced workflow that took care of both speed and quality standards.

The role of leadership was projected as crucial in conflict management. Effective leaders act as neutral facilitators, ensure that all team members are heard, and guide teams toward solutions that align with organizational objectives. Additionally, communication style was identified as a major factor behind influencing both the escalation and resolution of conflicts.

The discussion also showed out the importance of **negotiation skills and emotional intelligence**. Important techniques such as active listening, reframing problems, and focusing on shared goals were found to be effective in resolving any disagreements within team. Emotional intelligence helps individuals to manage reactions, understand others' perspectives, and maintain a constructive approach during team conflicts.

In terms of impact, unresolved conflicts were found to negatively affect team morale and team's entire productivity. However, when addressed properly, they can drastically improve trust, collaboration, and overall team efficiency in the longer run.

Some key takeaways from the interaction include the importance of **clear communication, early conflict resolution, defined roles, and maintain an open feedback culture** within the team.

A key insightful quote from the discussion that summarizes the perspective of entire discussion well is: **"Conflict is not the problem, how we handle it determines whether it becomes productive or harmful."**

Overall, this interaction provided valuable real-world insights into how conflicts are managed in professional environments and highlighted the importance of leadership, communication, and emotional intelligence in building effective teams.

Discussion Conducted by – Samarth S (23f2004763)

External Participant Details

Name: Mansi Devrukhkar

Role: Full stack web developer at Studio Frontier

Years of experience: 5

Industry: IT industry

Interviewed by: Shravani Bugdani

Key Insights from the Discussion

The discussion highlighted that conflicts in IT teams are quite common and often arise due to unclear communication and mismatched expectations. Ambiguous requirements and tight deadlines further increase the chances of misunderstandings among team members.

It was observed that strong interpersonal skills such as clear communication, leadership, and team building play a crucial role in minimizing conflicts. Emotional intelligence emerged as a key factor in effectively handling disagreements, especially in high-pressure situations like last-minute tasks. It helps individuals stay calm, respond thoughtfully, and maintain professional relationships even after conflicts are resolved.

Another important insight was the preference for resolving issues through open discussions within the team before escalating them to higher management. This approach builds trust, encourages collaboration, and leads to faster resolution. Additionally, focusing on common goals and adopting a win-win mindset ensures long-term teamwork and productivity.

Key Questions Explored

- What types of conflicts are most common in IT teams?
- What are the main causes of these conflicts?
- How does lack of communication impact team performance?
- What role does emotional intelligence play in conflict resolution?
- How can team members negotiate and resolve disagreements effectively?
- What strategies help in achieving win-win outcomes?
- What common mistakes do young professionals make during conflict

Relevant Anecdotes

A key takeaway from the discussion was reflected in the statement, *“Sometimes, it’s not about proving yourself right, but about working effectively as a team.”* This highlights the importance of collaboration over individual ego. Instead of focusing on winning an argument, team members should aim to find solutions together, ensuring better outcomes and stronger professional relationships.

By Vedant Goyal Roll No-23f2005291

External Participant Details

The interview was conducted with Shubham Singh, an IT professional with a background in Computer Science. He completed his Bachelors in Technology in CSE from NIT Uttarakhand and began his career as a Software Developer at Accenture, where he worked for around four years on multiple projects. He is currently working as a Senior Associate Consultant at Infosys and is gaining experience in technologies like Python while working in Agile environments.

Key Discussion Points and Insights

The discussion highlighted that conflicts are a common part of team dynamics, especially in Agile-based IT projects. One of the most frequent causes of conflict is differences in experience levels, which lead to disagreements in estimating the time required to complete tasks (story points). Senior developers often estimate tasks faster than junior developers, creating misunderstandings. Another major source of conflict is frequent changes in client requirements during the project lifecycle. Such changes disrupt planning and lead to confusion within the team. A real-life example shared by the participant involved a disagreement between frontend and backend approaches to solving a technical problem. The issue was resolved through discussion, testing both approaches, and selecting the backend solution based on better performance and reliability.

Common Mistakes by Young Professionals

Young IT professionals often make mistakes such as allowing ego to interfere while receiving feedback, misinterpreting guidance from seniors as criticism, and avoiding participation in team discussions. Lack of communication and hesitation to ask questions further increases misunderstandings.

Role in Career Growth

Conflict management and negotiation skills play a significant role in career growth. These skills help in improving teamwork, building leadership qualities, and managing client interactions effectively. Professionals who can handle conflicts calmly and communicate effectively are more likely to grow into leadership and managerial roles.

Advice for Handling Conflicts

The participant advised maintaining a calm and polite attitude while dealing with conflicts, especially with senior members. It is important to focus on resolving the issue rather than proving oneself right. Respectful communication and patience are key to maintaining healthy team relationships.

Advice for Students

Students should actively participate in meetings and improve their communication skills. Asking questions, sharing ideas, and listening to others are essential for effective collaboration. Developing strong communication skills early in the career can significantly help in future professional growth. Key Quotes from the Interview- • "If you are a new person, you need to learn and grow then don't take feedback on your ego." • "Understanding other's point of view and explaining your own clearly helps resolve most conflicts." • "Communication skill plays a major role in your future career."

Student Name: Deebhika Kumaran

Roll No: 23f1001691

Date of Interview: 23/03/2026

Interviewee: Ms. Vidhiya Kumar, Senior Business Analyst, UPS Technologies

Introduction

For the Strategies for Professional Growth course, I interviewed Ms. Vidhiya Kumar, a Senior Business Analyst at UPS Technologies with over ten years of experience across banking, e-learning, and IT services. Our conversation explored how she handles conflicts, negotiates with stakeholders, and uses emotional intelligence to keep her teams running smoothly.

Interview Summary

Negotiation as Core Skill Ms. Vidhiya sees negotiation as a core part of her role. She shared a straightforward example: a client wanted a pop-up on the UI, but her team proposed a simpler toggle feature instead, which achieved the same goal with less effort. She called this kind of workaround “a simple negotiation technique” and stressed that finding middle ground between what the client asks for and what the team can deliver quickly is something she does almost daily.

Choosing Ethics Over Comfort

I asked her what she does when people she’s personally close to in the team hold a wrong stance. Her answer was pretty direct - she goes with what’s right for the project, not with who she likes. She said, “As a manager and as a neutral person, we should always have that in mind.” She believes showing favouritism would quietly damage team morale over time, and I found that perspective quite honest.

Balancing Empathy with Accountability

One story that stood out was about a team member who was put on a Performance Improvement Plan. When he raised personal and emotional concerns, her team didn’t dismiss them - but they didn’t drop the expectations either. They held multiple conversations, set clear targets, and gave him room to improve. Eventually, he turned things around. As she put it, “We need to understand their emotions, but at the same time, we have to understand our team requirement.” It was a good example of empathy and firmness working together.

Disagreeing the Right Way

When I asked whether it’s okay to just agree with a manager even if they’re wrong, she said absolutely not - but how you say it matters more than what you say. She suggested backing your point with prior agreements and facts rather than bluntly saying “you’re wrong.” She also noted that newer professionals tend to stay silent out of dependency on seniors, though she was careful not to generalise this to all young employees.

Conclusion

This conversation made it clear that conflict management and negotiation aren't just "nice-to-have" soft skills. They're essential to how teams actually function. Ms. Vidhiya's experiences showed that ethical decision-making, emotional intelligence, and thoughtful communication are what hold teams together when things get difficult. It's motivated me to start practising these skills more intentionally, both in group projects now and in professional settings later.

Interview Conducted by Saksham Gupta

Participant Details

Name	Pranshu Gupta
Role	Interior Designer
Experience	3 Years
Industry	Interior Design
Interviewed by	Saksham Gupta

Key Insights from the Discussion

The discussion revealed that most conflicts in interior design arise from unclear client expectations, budget constraints, and creative differences. Pranshu highlighted that emotional intelligence (EQ) is the most critical skill — staying calm, listening empathetically, and refocusing on shared project goals is more effective than purely logical responses. He emphasized that transparent communication using visual tools like timelines and 3D renders helps prevent misunderstandings early. A win-win negotiation mindset — finding hybrid solutions that respect both client vision and professional judgment — was identified as the key to long-term team success.

Key Questions Explored

- What types of conflicts are most common in interior design teams, and what causes them?
- Can you share a real example where conflict impacted team performance, and how was it resolved?
- What personal approach and negotiation strategies do you use to manage disagreements?
- How important is emotional intelligence in handling workplace conflicts?
- What mistakes do young professionals make, and how have these skills shaped your career?
- What advice would you give students on developing collaboration and negotiation skills?

Key Anecdote

During a residential project, a two-week dispute over colour palette between the client and lead designer stalled procurement and delayed the entire timeline. The conflict was resolved through a structured review session with visual 3D renders and input from a neutral senior consultant — resulting in a hybrid solution that satisfied both parties. Pranshu's key takeaway: *"It's not about proving yourself right, but about creating a space that truly serves the client — together."*